Why Are Crocodiles Greener Than They Are Wide?

Evidence from a Fictional Swamp

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AISS Bytes · Mock presentation

All data, citations and results are made up. No crocodiles were harmed.

Motivation

- **Stylized fact:** crocodiles are greener than they are wide (Figure 1).
- The gap is large: about 2.7 green units per crocodile-width.
- Yet the literature studies length (Snout and Tail, 2019) and teeth (Jaw, 2021).
- Research question: is the green–wide gap causal, or do wide crocodiles simply hide?

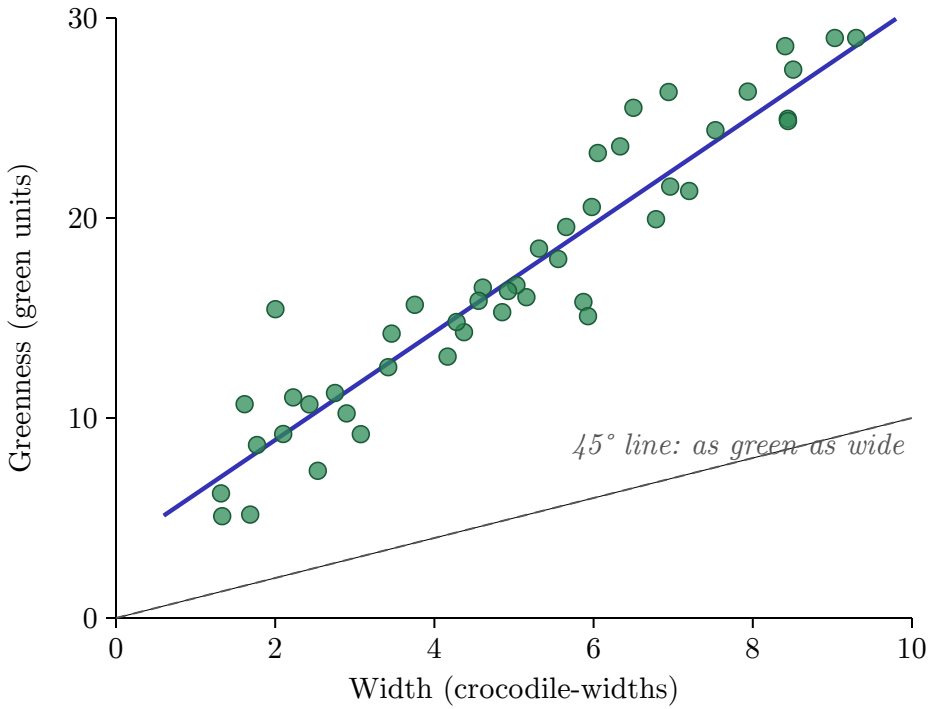


Figure 1: Every crocodile lies above the 45° line

Empirical Strategy

$$Green_{ist} - Wide_{ist} = \alpha + \beta\, Swamp_{st} + X'_i\gamma + \mu_s + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{ist}$$

- i crocodile, s swamp, t season; X_{i} includes tail length and mood.
- Instrument $Swamp_{st}$ with distance to the nearest lily pad.
  - Exclusion restriction: lily pads affect the gap only through swampiness.
  - Crocodiles do not eat lily pads (see Appendix Z).
- Main threat: wide crocodiles refuse to be measured.

Main Results

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Dep. var.: Green − Wide	OLS	Swamp FE	IV
Swampiness	2.31***	2.58***	2.71***
	(0.38)	(0.41)	(0.52)
Tail length	0.04	0.03	0.02
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Mood controls	No	Yes	Yes
Swamp and season FE	No	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,312	1,312	1,312
R^2	0.18	0.42	–
First-stage F	–	–	23.4

Notes: Standard errors clustered by swamp in parentheses. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1. All numbers are invented for this mock presentation.

Conclusion

- Crocodiles are robustly greener than they are wide.
- The result survives fixed effects, an instrument and a very nervous research assistant.
- Policy implication: if you must measure a crocodile, measure the colour.
- Next steps: alligators (external validity) and a longer tape measure.

Thank you! Questions?